# Pre-workshop Setup – GitHub Onboarding

### TCUP Hub Data Science Workshop

November 5–6, 2026

**Complete this before Day One, November 5.** Existing account holders can start by signing in. Use a browser; no Git installation or command line is needed.

## Overview

We will be using GitHub and GitHub Codespaces for the workshop. This pre-workshop activity will help you get familiar with GitHub. *You will not need to install additional programs or use the command line for this activity.* If you get stuck reach out to me or one of the other helpers.

**Remote support:** - Jason Tinant (jtinant@olc.edu), - Brian Yandell (brian.yandell@wisc.edu), - Nate Quarderer (nathan.quarderer@colorado.edu).

Use email to ask questions. If you have not heard back, in a reasonable time, email another listed helper. Bring unresolved issues to Thursday's 8 a.m. breakfast help.

*Keep your GitHub and ORCID passwords and verification codes private.*

**In-person help:** Thursday, November 5, 8:00 a.m. breakfast help opportunity (San Antonio time).

## Why GitHub? and some terminology

**GitHub** is a website where you can store project files, keep track of changes, and collaborate with others. Your **GitHub username** identifies your account. A **repository**, often called a "repo," holds a project's files—such as code, notebooks, data, and documentation—along with a record of how they have changed over time. A **commit** records a set of changes with a short message explaining what changed. This history helps you understand earlier work, compare versions, and return to a previous version when needed.

**GitHub Codespaces** provides a workspace where you can open, edit, and run code in your browser instead of installing specific software on your local machine. *The repository holds the project and its recorded history; the Codespace gives you a place to work on it.*

## Step 1. Sign into your account

If you already have an account, open GitHub sign-in. Use your existing account and complete any required verification. If you cannot sign in, use the recovery option on that page before creating another account. Keep your password and recovery codes private; facilitators do not need them.

If you do not have an account, open GitHub sign-up, follow the prompts and verify your email. Choose a username you are comfortable using to identify your work. A free personal account is sufficient for this onboarding activity; paid Codespaces usage is a separate question. See GitHub's account guidance. Institution-managed accounts may have different rules. If signup/access is restricted, use the support route above; do not bypass institutional controls.

## Step 2. Find your GitHub username

Open your account menu and choose your profile. Locate the username and copy the profile address from the browser bar for your own reference. A display name can differ from a username. Keep the address handy if an organizer requests it; these instructions do not require posting it to a public participant list.

## Step 3. Create your own practice repository

Use the **+** menu on GitHub and select **New repository**. Choose your personal account as owner, name it `tcup-github-practice` (or another name if already in use), choose **Private**, and enable **Add README**. Create the repository. Use only a harmless practice sentence; no data upload or collaborator access is needed. This repository is separate from the workshop's public repository.

Open `README.md`, return to the file list and locate the current branch name, usually `main`. A branch lets you work on a separate version of these files.

## Step 4. Make and find one small change

1. Open the branch selector, type `readme-practice` and create that branch from the default branch. If it already exists, select it.
2. Confirm the selector says **readme-practice**. Open `README.md` and choose the pencil/edit control.
3. Add "Practicing GitHub for the workshop." Preview the edit.
4. Choose **Commit changes**, enter a short message such as "Add practice note," and commit directly to **readme-practice**.
5. Return to the repository's file list. **Select readme-practice again** if the selector shows the default branch, then reopen `README.md`. Locate the saved sentence and the latest commit link/history.

Your edit belongs to the practice branch; it will not appear on the default branch. If GitHub displays a **Compare & pull request** banner, you can ignore it for this exercise. No pull request or merge is required. Keep the repository link for your own reference; you do not need to publish or share it. Reach out to the support route above if you get stuck.

*These instructions are adapted from GitHub's Hello World guide.*